March 2026

Suzanne P. Clark, President & CEO
U.S. Chamber of Commerce
1615 H Street NW
Washington, DC 20062
Phone: (202) 659-6000

Dear Ms. Clark,

The skills deficit that American businesses cite most consistently — inability to work in teams, lack of problem-solving initiative, poor communication across difference — is not primarily a technical skills gap. It is a civic skills gap. The National Experiential Civic Education Framework addresses it at the source.

NECEF proposes embedding hands-on civic programs in schools: community service, emergency preparedness, infrastructure stewardship, and collaborative leadership challenges. Students who complete this framework enter the workforce already practiced in the foundational behaviors every employer requires — cooperative problem-solving, leadership under pressure, accountability to a team, and the ability to work alongside people different from themselves.

The business case extends beyond workforce preparation. Civic disengagement, declining social trust, and community fragmentation translate directly into political instability, regulatory unpredictability, and communities less capable of supporting thriving businesses. The Chamber has a direct interest in the civic health of the operating environment — and this framework is the most cost-effective intervention available.

The cost is $57-$87 per student per year. The framework draws on existing federal infrastructure with no new bureaucracy. It has full state and local control built in, addressing the overreach concern before it is raised. And it has a rigorous outcome measurement system tied directly to funding continuation.

I am asking the Chamber to formally endorse the NECEF white paper, advocate for its adoption through your congressional relationships, and co-sponsor school programs in Chamber member communities. Your endorsement provides the business credibility that immediately neutralizes the cost and overreach objections for Republican legislators.

Respectfully,

Gina Aulabaugh